

HISTORY OF DIVISION WITHIN CHRISTIANITY

The following article is not written to be comparative but written from Christian perspective and at the very least be unbiased, accurate, easy, informative and helpful for a Muslim daaee, when she or he engages with a Christian for dawah.

Christianity in its 2000 year history has been divided into many branches (denominations), sects and cults based on differences in theology, doctrine, ritual, tradition, church government and political motivation.

~~Christianity did not start out as a unified movement. After the sudden departure of Jesus (death around 30-33 CE) the disciples (Apostles) of Jesus got together try to make sense of all that they had experienced. The small group of Jews that followed Jesus at that time was seen as a Jewish cult/sect which shortly after (around 33-40 CE) came to be known as Christians. These early Christians were struggling with issues such as fundamental beliefs of their faith, laws and rituals to follow, and most importantly status and mission of Jesus Christ.

~~Officially the history of Christian Church began, as in the Bible, ten days after the ascension of Jesus when the Holy Spirit descended upon the disciples and other followers on the feast of Pentecost (fifty days after Jesus' resurrection from death) and enabled them to speak in tongues (unintelligible utterances or speaking a previously unknown language). On that occasion Peter, one of the disciples, stood up and addressed the crowd of believers and non-believers which is considered to be the first Christian sermon. The disciples then started missionary campaigns. They first started to convert their fellow Jews than went onto convert the gentiles into Christianity.

~~A close observation reveals, the disciples were dispersed at a time when there were no fixed formulation of Christianity. Each of them probably had different take on what the significance of Jesus' life was. Some of them concentrated on his death, resurrection and ascension, and were trying to make sense of these events. While others concentrated on his life and teaching and were trying to propagate that. We can see in the Book of Acts (from Bible), that there were different groups that were in competition with each other. Some of them insisted strongly on adherence of Jewish laws in the Torah while others were more open and had a lax attitude towards the adherence of the Jewish law.

The early group of Christians (disciples and followers) were probably lead by Peter and or 'James brother of Jesus' based in Jerusalem. These early followers of Christ viewed themselves as part of a reform movement within Judaism who believed Yahweh (God of the old testament) to be the only true God and considered Jesus to be the messiah (Christ) prophesied in the Jewish scriptures. These early Christians were all ethnically Jewish or Jewish converts and were known as **Jewish Christians**.

Right around this time (around 35 CE) an individual name Saul of Tarsus a devout and soundly educated Jew came into the picture. This Greek speaking Jew, one of the Pharisees, one of the strongest persecutors of the early Jewish Christians, had a blinding vision of Jesus Christ on the road to Damascus in which Jesus asked why he was persecuting him (Jesus, i.e. his followers). This incident was a turning point for Christianity . **Saul converted and changed his name to Paul.**

~~This newly appointed (self-appointed and proclaimed) apostle, also known as "Apostle to the gentiles", became the greatest preacher of that time. He traveled extensively throughout Roman empire converting gentiles to the new faith and establishing new churches. He wrote many letters to these new gentile converts (and churches) advising and explaining their new faith. He fought hard on behalf of the gentile converts to convince the Jerusalem leadership to get rid of circumcision, dietary

and other mosaic laws, positions that were not favored by the early Jewish Christians.

~~His teaching and writing shaped modern Christianity as we know today. Over half of the books of new testament were written by him. The group consisting gentile converts and followers of Paul are sometimes called as **Pauline Christians**.

Another group, Gnostic Christians, came into existence during the later part of first and mostly in second century CE . This group of Christians seem to have infused elements of Christianity with Greek philosophy. They believed that they have secret knowledge about God (acquired from Jesus), in a dualistic world (material world is bad, the spirit world is good) and considered the God of the Old Testament (as creator of material old) to be inferior to the true God revealed by Jesus.

BASICALLY BY THE END OF THE FIRST CENTURY CE:

Christianity was divided into three main religious movements: the Jewish Christians, Pauline Christians and Gnostic Christians. In addition to these there were many other smaller groups with varying degrees of belief of Christianity.

~~The original followers of Jesus, the Jewish Christians, were literally wiped out during the first (66-70 CE) and second (132-135 CE) Jewish revolt against the Romans. Whatever remained of this group later on deemed unorthodox and eventually as heretic (on and after fourth century CE) by the dominant orthodox (Pauline) Christians.

~~Gnostic Christianity had a decent following in late first to third century CE but never really gained traction afterwards. By fourth century CE Gnostic Christians were labeled as non-Christians/heretics and were persecuted by ruling Roman Christian authority. This heretic cult still survive today with very few adherents.

~~The Pauline Christians gained prominence and became the main stream Christian movement after the fall of Jerusalem and destruction of the great Temple complex in 70 CE. **Almost all of the today's Christian faith groups trace their history back to the Pauline Christian movement.**

By the end of the 1st century CE, early Christianity now being dominated mostly by Greek speaking gentle converts (Pauline Christians) away from Jerusalem began to be recognized internally and externally as a separate religion from Judaism.

In Second, Third And Beginning Of Fourth Century CE

Christians endured waves/periods of persecutions in the hands of Roman empire. This was also the time when Christianity totally separated itself from its origin, Judaism. This period saw arguments and debates among Christians on doctrinal issues, content of sacred text (new testament) and church leadership. This period also saw groups such as Marcionism, Montanism, Adoptionism, Sabellianism, Donatism, Arianism come into existence.

Marcionism:

An early Christian movement, founded by Marcion of Sinope, son of a bishop, around 144 CE.

Key features of this movement:

- rejected the old testament, accepted Paul as the chief Apostle.
 - believed Jesus was the savior sent by the higher God and god of old testament was a lower god.
- This sect was condemned as heretic from early on and eventually died out after fourth century CE.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Marcionites>, <https://carm.org/what-is-marcionism>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/overview/>, <http://www.newadvent.org/cathen/09645c.htm>,
<http://www.jesuswordsonly.com/books/56-marcionism.html>,
<http://www.churchhistory101.com/century2.php>

Montanism:

Montanism was founded in mid-second century (around 156-172 CE) by a prophet named Montanus and two prophetess named Maximilla and Prisca.

Key features of this movement:

- Montanus, Maximilla and Prisca prophesied in a frenzied ecstatic state claiming the gift of prophecy.
 - they claimed that they were the last manifestation of the Paraclete (the Comforter as mentioned in the Gospel of John 14:16).
 - they believed the end of the world was soon to come and that the New Jerusalem would soon come to earth in Phrygia, in the little town of Pepuza.
 - they recognized female leadership like bishops and presbyters.
 - they encouraged followers to embrace persecution and martyrdom.
- This movement had some following early on but eventually died out with the death of the three founders.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Montanism>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/history/montanism/>,
<http://www.earlychristianhistory.info/montanus.html>, <http://www.gotquestions.org/montanism.html>,
<http://www.newadvent.org/cathen/10521a.htm>, <http://www.tertullian.org/montanism.htm>,
<http://www.churchhistory101.com/century2.php>

Adoptionism (also known as Dynamic Monarchianism):

An early Christian movement with unique belief and nature of Jesus formally espoused by Theodotus of Byzantium (around 190 CE).

Key features of this movement:

- denied the eternal pre-existence of Jesus as the Christ (as a divine deity).
 - believed Jesus was born a normal human being and became divine later during his baptism (or his ascension) when God Chose Jesus as His adopted Son.
- This movement was deemed heretic and eventually died out around fourth century CE. The movement was seen again in eighth century and in twelfth century CE for a short period of time.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Adoptionism>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/overview/>,

<https://carm.org/node/2698>, <http://i-cias.com/e.o/adoptionism.htm>,
<http://www.globalserve.net/~yuku/bbl/8ado.htm>

Sabellianism (also known as Modalistic Monarchianism):

An early Christian movement of early third century (around 215 to 220 CE) presented by Sabellius (priest and theologian) in Rome.

Key features of this movement:

- rejected trinity in favor of belief in only one God.
 - believed the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are modes or manifestations of the one God.
- This movement had some support early on but later deemed heretic and eventually dwindled down to non-existence by sixth century CE.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Sabellianism>,
<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Sabellianism>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/overview/>, <https://carm.org/monarchianism>

Donatism:

An early Christian movement in north Africa began in early fourth century (around 312 CE), which was championed and named after bishop Donatus Magnus.

Key features of this movement:

- disagreed (primary disagreement) with the rest of the early church over the validity of sacraments dispensed by priests and bishops (after being restored having performed appropriate penance) who had fallen away under the Roman persecution.
- disqualified apostate Christians, restoring faith after having performed appropriate penance, from leadership in the Church.

This movement was initially seen as a schism within but later deemed heretical and the movement eventually faded away by seventh century CE.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Donatist>,
<http://i-cias.com/e.o/donatism.htm>,
<http://www.earlychristianhistory.info/donatus.html>

Arianism:

Named after its primary proponent Arius, an Alexandrian priest, an early fourth century (around 318-321 CE) movement based on disagreement over nature and person of Jesus (Christology) .

Key features of this movement:

- the Father alone is God: He alone is self-existent, unbegotten, eternal, immutable.
 - the Logos (pre-incarnate Jesus) was a divine being created (only-begotten Son) by God the Father before time began.
 - through the Son, everything else was created including the Holy Spirit, who was subservient to the Son as the Son was to the Father.
 - Jesus (a lesser god) is a created being with divine attributes who can be worshipped as God.
- This movement had good following for few decades in the fourth century and was considered the

biggest threat to mainstream Trinitarians. This heretic movement survived for few more centuries in pockets of population until eight century CE.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://earlychurch.org.uk/arianism-schaff.html>, <http://www.encyclopedia.com/topic/Arianism.aspx>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/overview> <http://www.churchhistory101.com/century4.php>,
<http://www.historyworld.net/wrldhis/PlainTextHistories.asp?historyid=ac61>,
<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Arianism>, <https://carm.org/arianism>

In early fourth century CE Roman emperor Constantine's conversion (in 312 CE) to Christianity (mainstream Pauline Christianity) was a major turning point for Christianity. The Roman Empire recognized Christianity as a valid religion in 313 CE. Christianity flourished as scores of pagans found it convenient to convert to the emperor's faith.

~~After **the first Council of Nicaea in 325 CE, summoned by Emperor Constantine, the first uniform Christian doctrine, called the Nicene Creed** was established. This council defined unity of beliefs for the whole of Christendom in favor of the mainstream Trinitarian orthodoxy. From this point on all the other early Christian (not conforming to Nicene Creed) movements were declared heretic. **In 380 CE Christianity became the official religion of Roman empire.**

For The Next Six Hundred Years (Until 1054 CE)

The mainstream Christian (Pauline Christian) Church, also called Catholic (universal) Church, went through relatively calm and stable period compared to its tumultuous past. **The first significant split** in this period came from the Church of the East (including Assyrian church of the east), which broke away following the Christological controversy over Nestorianism in 431 CE. **The second /last significant split** in this period came from breaking away of the Syriac and Coptic churches, with the dissenting churches becoming today's Oriental Orthodoxy.

Church of the East/The Assyrian Church (also called Nestorian Church):

This first significant split was based on Nestorius's view (**known as Nestorianism**) of Christ which was condemned heretical at the Council of Ephesus in 431 CE (and later on again in Council of Chalcedon in 451 CE), and the conflict over this view led to the Nestorian schism, separating the Church of the East/Assyrian Church of the East from the main stream Catholic (universal) Church.

~~Nestorianism is based on the belief put forth by Nestorius, Patriarch of Constantinople, around 428 CE, that emphasized the disunity (two distinct and separate) of the human and divine natures of Christ.

Key features of this branch:

- they believed the human and divine essences of Christ are separate and that there are two persons, the man Jesus Christ and the divine Son of God (or Logos), which dwelt in the man.
- they rejected the term Theotokos (Bearer or mother of God) for the Virgin Mary, suggesting instead the title Christotokos (Bearer or mother of Christ), because in their opinion Mary gave birth to only the human person of Jesus.
- rejected such terminology as "God suffered" or "God was crucified", because it was the human

nature of Jesus Christ which suffered, not the divine nature.

After the council of Ephesus in 431 CE, Nestorius was stripped of his position and exiled. Institutions, bishops and individuals that supported Nestorius were persecuted and exiled. These events contributed to the mass exodus of Nestorius's supporters and institutions to the Sasanian Empire, where they affiliated with the local Christian community, known as the Church of the East/The Assyrian Church.

~~The Sassanid Emperor, hostile to the Roman Emperor, seized this opportunity and gave support and protection to the Nestorian party which solidified the Nestorian schism. The Sassanid Emperor then took active steps to establish the primacy of the Nestorian party within the Church of the East. For next couple of centuries the church flourished and expanded through missionary activity into India, Tibet, China, and Mongolia.

~~After the Muslim conquest of Persia (633-654) many adherents converted to Islam and the remnants thrived under Muslim protection for few more centuries (until 10th century CE). Over the centuries, the Church moved away from strict Nestorian views and modified and shaded much of it and eventually giving it up and adopting the mainstream view.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://i-cias.com/e.o/nestorianism.htm>,

http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Nestorian_Christianity,

<http://www.christianity.com/church/church-history/timeline/301-600/the-nestorian-controversy-11629695.html>,

<http://www.gotquestions.org/Nestorianism.html>,

<http://www.reclaimingthemind.org/blog/2010/05/heresies-nestorianism-a-divided-christ/>,

<http://www.cnewa.org/default.aspx?ID=1&pagetypeID=9&sitecode=HQ&pageno=1>

Oriental Orthodox Church (Old Oriental Churches, Miaphysite Church):

The second split (also known as Chalcedonian schism) came when several of the ancient eastern churches (such as Coptic, Ethiopian, Eritrean, Syriac, Malankara Syrian and Armenian Apostolic churches) known as the Oriental Orthodox Church rejected the main stream Christological definition adopted by Council of Chalcedon (451 CE). They rejected council's definition of Christ to have two distinct natures--fully human and fully divine--united in one person, in favor Miaphysitism following closely the teaching of St. Cyril of Alexandria.

Key features of this branch:

-- they believe that Christ has only one nature, at once human and divine which is known as Miaphysitism.

-- they recognize only the first three ecumenical councils—the First Council of Nicaea, the First Council of Constantinople and the First Council of Ephesus. Their doctrinal position is based on the teachings of these three ecumenical councils.

-- all six churches of this branch are hierarchically autonomous from each other, lacking any equivalent to the Roman Catholic Pope (or to the Eastern Orthodox Patriarch of Constantinople).

In recent times Chalcedonian schism is not seen with the same relevance and numerous conferences have been held aiming at theological reconciliation.

Resources and for more Info:

http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Oriental_Orthodoxy,

<http://pluralism.org/affiliates/student/allen/Oriental-Orthodox/Home.html>,

<https://www.oikoumene.org/en/church-families/orthodox-churches-oriental>,

The Great Schism Of 1054 CE

The Great Schism Of 1054 CE And Birth Of Roman Catholic And Eastern Orthodox Church

Until 1054 CE, Western (Latin) and Eastern (Greek) branches, were branches of the same body—the One, Holy, Catholic (Universal) and Apostolic Church. In 1054 CE, a formal split known as the Great Schism, also called the East-West Schism, divided the main stream Christianity (universal church) into Roman Catholic (Western-Latin branches) Church with its seat of power in Rome and the Eastern Orthodox (Eastern-Greek branches) Church with its seat of power in Constantinople.

~~Even though usually dated to 1054 CE, the schism was the result of an extended period (beginning in the 4th century CE) of tension and disagreement over theological, linguistic, political, and geographic lines, between then Western-Latin and Eastern-Greek Churches. These various factors finally came to a head-on collision in 1054 CE, when Pope Leo IX's representative Cardinal Humbert excommunicated Patriarch Michael Cerularius of Constantinople, the leader of the Eastern church. The Patriarch Cerularius condemned the Pope and excommunicated Humbert in return, causing the official schism.

The following are the main reasons that eventually led to the split (schism):

- (a) The Filioque controversy usually cited as the primary reason for the split. The Latin word filioque means "and from the Son." It was inserted into the Nicene Creed by Western Church, thus changing the phrase pertaining to the origin of the Holy Spirit from "who proceeds from the Father" to "who proceeds from the Father and the Son." This was done to emphasize Christ's divinity, but Eastern Church rejected the alteration and objected to its new meaning. Eastern Church believes both the Spirit and the Son have their origin in the Father.
- (b) Western Church's belief of Papal supremacy of Roman pope, Patriarch of Rome, as the visible head of the church on earth and spiritual successor of St. Peter was another reason. They hold that Roman Pope has supreme authority (including that of over church councils and other Patriarchs) within Christendom. But Eastern Church holds that the primacy of the Patriarch of Rome (the Pope) is one of honor only, and that he does not have the authority to determine policy for other jurisdictions or to change the decisions of Ecumenical Councils. His authority is thus no greater or lesser than any of the other Patriarchs.
- (c) Western Church used unleavened bread for the celebration of the Eucharist, while in the Eastern Church only leavened bread was used. Eastern Church objected to this Western practice considering it an innovation.
- (d) Western Church required their clergy (priests and bishops) to be celibate. The Eastern Church resented the Roman enforcement of clerical celibacy. Eastern Church allowed marriage of parish priests if their marriage had taken place when they were still laymen.

~~This schism (split) became permanent after the brutal sack of Constantinople by Roman Catholic crusaders in 1204 CE during the Fourth Crusade. This division remains in effect till today. This was the first major division in Christianity.

~~Several attempts were made towards reconciliation but none of those materialized to meaningful result up until 1453, when the last of the Byzantine Emperor, Constantine XI, based in

Constantinople (modern day Istanbul) was defeated by the Muslim Turks. In recent times discussion between both parties are being resumed looking for ways towards reconciliation.

Resources and for more Info:

http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/History_of_Christianity,
<http://3lotus.com/en/Reflections;%20Misc/Christian-schisms.htm>,
<http://www.britannica.com/event/Schism-of-1054>,
<http://www.christianitytoday.com/ch/1990/issue28/2820.html>,
<http://www.christianity.com/church/church-history/timeline/901-1200/schism-between-east-and-west-began-11629784.html>,
<http://orthodoxinfo.com/general/greatschism.aspx>,
http://www.catholicbridge.com/catholic/orthodox/timeline_history_of_catholic_orthodox_relations.php,
,
http://www.academia.edu/506089/The_Great_Schism_Between_East_and_West_in_1054)

From Eleventh To Sixteenth Century CE

The period from the great schism between Eastern and Western Church to just before the period of the Reformation in the west, the Western (Roman Catholic) church saw rise of few schismatic groups like Cathars, Waldensians, Lollards and Hussites . Movements such as Waldensians, Lollards and Hussites are considered to be the precursors to the Protestant Reformation .
~~The Eastern Orthodox Church did not go through any major change or schism after the eleventh century. The Eastern churches would eventually be organized on national lines, but all conform to the same doctrines. **More information in major denominations section.**

Cathars (also known as Albigenses):

A strong Christian movement of medieval period began sometime between eleventh to twelfth century CE, and flourished in some areas of Southern Europe, particularly southern France , northern Italy and northern Spain in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries CE. The movement was declared as heretic by Roman catholic Church from early on.

Key features of this movement:

--they believed that there were two gods. The good God (God of New Testament) of the invisible and spiritual world. And the evil God (God of old testament) of the visible and material world.

-- only accepted teaching based on New testament.

--they had a negative view of the of Roman Catholic Church and rejected many of its teachings such as marriage, sacraments, Eucharist, baptism etc.

Cathars were strongly resisted by Roman catholic Church with intense persecution. The movement disappeared by early fifteenth century CE.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.cathar.info/>, <http://philipcoppens.com/catharism.html>,
<http://atheism.about.com/od/christianheresyheretics/p/CatharCatharism.htm>,
<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Cathari>, <http://www.russianbooks.org/montsegur/montsegur1.htm>

Waldensians:

A Christian movement started by Peter Waldo, a wealthy merchant in France, between 1170-1176 CE, who gave away all of his property to preach and to follow Christ in poverty and simplicity. Early on the Roman Catholic Church accepted the group, but later some of Waldensian teachings came into conflict with the Church. And by early 13th century CE the Waldensians were declared a

heretical group and was subject to intense persecution.

Key features of the movement:

- rejected some of the seven sacraments in favor of only accepting baptism and the communion.
- rejected purgatory (an intermediate state after death for sin remission), indulgences and prayers for the dead. In their view all believers are either saved through faith in Christ and non-believers go to everlasting hell or destruction.

- rejected the veneration of saints and transubstantiation of bread and wine during Eucharist.

Under intense persecution for the next few centuries their number dwindled down and some returned to catholic Church. The majority of the remnants of the movement in the sixteenth century adopted the teachings of the Reformed Protestant Church in the Presbyterian and Calvinist tradition. This movement is considered to be a precursor to the Protestant Reformation. The Waldensian Church of present day considers itself to be a Protestant church of the Reformed tradition.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.thereformation.info/waldensians.htm>, <http://www.newadvent.org/cathen/15527b.htm>,
<http://www.waldensian.org/3-history/>

Lollards (Wycliffite) followers of John Wycliffe:

It was a rebellious religious and political movement in 14th century CE in England. John Wycliffe, theologian and Oxford professor, argued for Scriptures as the only authoritative reliable guide to the truth about God and Christianity, hence Christians should rely on Bible instead of teachings of popes and priests. So he took the initiative for the first complete translation of the Bible into English from Latin Vulgate.

Key features of the movement:

- rejected transubstantiation and believed in the spiritual rather than the physical presence of Jesus in Eucharist.

- rejected special prayers for the dead, pilgrimages, clerical celibacy, reverence and offerings to images, and confession to a priest.

- rejected Roman Church, claiming that the office of the papacy lacked scriptural justification.

Wycliffe was condemned and excommunicated by Roman Catholic Church and he died in 1384. By early 15th century the movement was condemned as heretic. The joint force of state and church's persecution drove the remainder of the movement underground until Protestant and English Reformation of 16th century CE. The movement is considered a precursor to the Protestant Reformation and was mostly absorbed by modern-day Protestant groups.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.britannica.com/topic/Lollards>, <http://www.newadvent.org/cathen/09333a.htm>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/history/british/middle_ages/loollards_01.shtml,
<http://www.britannica.com/biography/John-Wycliffe>

Hussites follower of Jan Hus (Priest, Czech religious Reformer and teacher):

A Christian movement of early 15th century CE. Jan Hus (1369–1415 CE), a key figure of Bohemian (Czech Republic) Reformation and considered as one of the forerunners of the Protestant Reformation. Jan Hus was influenced by the writings of John Wycliffe. He promoted the reading of the New and Old Testament by lay people in the common language and the idea to be able to interpret for themselves. He was initially excommunicated by Roman Catholic church and later was condemned as heretic and was burned at the stake.

Key features of the movement:

- they believed in administering Holy Communion of both the Body and Blood (bread and wine) of

Jesus Christ to all Christians (at that time only priest were allowed).

--they held precedence of the Bible and the scriptures over Church leaders and councils.

Hussites gained prominence in 15th century CE in Bohemia but later on they went through schism, intense persecution and assimilation.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www2.kenyon.edu/projects/margin/hussites.htm>, <http://tisk.cirkev.cz/en/czech-church-history/the-hussite-movement-and-the-reformation/>, <http://www.britannica.com/topic/Hussite>

The Sixteenth Century Reformation (Also Called Protestant Reformation)

THE SIXTEENTH CENTURY REFORMATION (ALSO CALLED PROTESTANT REFORMATION) WITHIN WESTERN (ROMAN CATHOLIC) CHRISTIANITY

The 16th-century Reformation was mostly religious and to some extent political, intellectual and social revolution that split Western (Roman Catholic) Church and gave rise to the protestant denominations we see today. The other by product of 16th century Reformation which was mostly political (English Reformation) was the Anglican Church (also known as Church of England).

~~The Protestant Reformation was initiated by German Roman Catholic monk, Martin Luther, when he in his quest to reform the Roman Catholic Church by eliminating some of its abuses involving the sale of indulgences and some of the other church practices, posted his 95 propositions (or theses) against the teachings of the Roman Catholic Church on the Castle Church door at Wittenberg, Germany in 1517 CE. The Reformation got further steam and spread throughout Europe through the work of Huldrych Zwingli and John Calvin.

~~The immediate result of 16th century Reformation was three major divisions or traditions of Protestantism (which are Lutheranism, Anabaptism, Calvinism) and Anglicanism, out of Western (Roman Catholic) Church.

Lutheranism:

It is the first major protestant movement out of 16th century Reformation. Lutheranism was founded upon the teachings of Martin Luther (1483-1546) in 1517 CE. **More information in major denominations section.**

Anabaptism:

A radical movement out of the Protestant reformation, was most probably founded in Switzerland by George Blaurock, Conrad Grebel, and Felix Manz in 1525. The Mennonites, Hutterites, and Amish are all direct descendants of this movement. **More information in major denominations section.**

Reformed Christianity (Calvinism-Reformed and Presbyterian churches):

One of the early movement out of Protestant Reformation in Switzerland that broke off from the Roman Catholic Church. This movement began in 1522 in Switzerland under the leadership of Huldrych Zwingli and later on was firmly established by John Calvin in 1536. **More information in major denominations section.**

Anglicanism (Church of England):

Began in 1534, when King Henry VIII of England split from the Roman Catholic church because the pope (i.e. Catholic Church) would not grant an annulment to his marriage with Catherine of Aragon. Even though considered a result of 16th century Reformation, this split from Roman Catholic church was more personal and political than theological. **More information in major denominations section.**

Seventeenth Century To Present

This period saw rise of many denominations out of the Protestant reformation. Some early divisions of this period came out of Roman Catholic Church as a late result of the Protestant reformation. Many of the later denominations specially between 19th and 20th century are the result of schism and assimilation of different Protestant movements.

~~Some of the notable divisions/denominations of this period are Baptist, Religious Society of Friends (Quakers), Pietists , Methodist , Episcopal, Mormons, Seventh-Day Adventist, Jehovah's Witnesses, Pentecostal/The Charismatic Movement etc.

Baptist:

This movement began when an Anglican priest John Smyth broke his ties with Church of England in 1606 and later (in 1609) moved to Holland with a group of English Separatists and formed a Baptist Church. After Smyth's departure to join the Mennonites, his colleague Thomas Helwys and other members of the group returned to England in 1612 and established a Baptist church in London. **More information in major denominations section.**

Religious Society of Friends (or Quakers):

It was founded by George Fox at the tail end of Europe's Protestant Reformation around 1650 CE in England. This movement had some following early on but eventually was not able to become of anything of significance. The movement still survives today among few believers.

Key features of the movement:

--God is knowable by every human being and belief in the possibility of direct, unmediated communion with God. God dwelled in the hearts of his obedient people and the Spirit of God will lead believers into all truth if they are faithful in hearing and obeying God's voice in their hearts.
--They don't believe in any sacraments or formal liturgies or ceremonies and also refuse to take oaths.

-- Quakers do not consider the Bible to be the final authority or the only source of sacred wisdom

because God is within the faithful, believers could follow their own inner guide (inner voice).

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.fgcquaker.org/explore/faqs-about-quakers#believe?>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/quakers_1.shtml,
<http://www.quakermaps.com/info>, <http://www.history.com/topics/quakers>

Pietists (Pietism):

This movement began within Lutheranism in Germany in the seventeenth century. It is generally believed, this movement was founded by Lutheran pastor Philipp Jakob Spener (1635-1705) who saw a decline in practical piety in the Lutheran church. Members of this movement desired to have a deeper personal faith as opposed to the often cold liturgical faith of the Lutheran church. Many of the members remained within the Lutheran fold, while others branched out and founded churches of their own.

Key features of this movement (holds on to Orthodox Lutheran theology but):

-- encourage personal piety and Bible study.

-- emphasizes on the priesthood and preaching of all believers.

This movement eventually faded away through assimilation within Lutheranism or other protestant movement by 19th century.

Resources and for more Info:

<http://www.encyclopedia.com/topic/Pietism.aspx>,
<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/denominations/pietism/>
<http://www.patheos.com/blogs/justandsinner/why-we-should-stop-using-the-term-pietism/>,

Methodist (Methodism):

This movement began in 1738 in England within Church of England (Anglican Church) by brothers John and Charles Wesley. The movement officially split from Church of England in 1784. **More information in major denominations section.**

Episcopal (Anglicanism in United states) Church:

It was the new adopted name of 'Church of England (Anglican Church) in American colonies' after American Revolution, when (1776-1789) it became separate from the Church of England. **More information in major denominations section.**

Mormon (Mormonism) Church:

Also known as the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints (LDS-Church) was founded in New York in 1830 by Joseph Smith. Mormon Church is considered a Christian cult (not a branch or denomination) by majority of the Christians. **More information in major denominations section.**

Seventh-Day Adventist:

It is a protestant denomination (some Christians consider it to be a cult) that grew out of the prophetic Millerite movement in the United States during the middle part of the 19th century and was formally established in 1863 under the guidance of prophetess Ellen G. White. **More information in major denominations section.**

Jehovah's Witnesses:

This movement (officially 'The Watch Tower Bible and Tract Society') was founded in the USA towards the end of the 19th century (around 1872), under the leadership of Charles Taze Russell. This movement is also considered as a Christian cult (not a branch or denomination) by majority of the Christians. **More information in major denominations section.**

Pentecostalism (The Charismatic Movement):

Began in 1901, when Agnes Ozman, a student at Charles Fox Parham's (perceived founder of the movement) Bethel Bible School in Topeka, Kansas, spoke in tongues (foreign language previously unknown to a specific individual). But the beginning of the widespread Pentecostal movement in the United States is generally considered to have begun with Parham's student William Seymour's three-year-long Azusa Street Revival in 1906. **More information in major denominations section.**

For More Information (Some Sources Used for this Article):

<http://www.astudyofdenominations.com/overview/#sthash.ljOhbl1y.dpbs>,
<http://www.pbs.org/wgbh/pages/frontline/shows/religion/first/diversity.html>,
<http://www.churchhistory101.com/index.php>,
http://christianity.about.com/od/denominations/a/denominations_3.htm,
<http://www.theopedia.com/church-history>,
<http://www.slideshare.net/TheWedge/brief-history-of-christianity-division-of-the-church>,
http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/History_of_Christianity,
<https://carm.org/church-history-outline>,
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Christianity/Historical-Development>,
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_Christianity,
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Christian_denomination,